

Hosting the Career Transition Intake Form on Render

The intake form is a Flask web application hosted on Render as a Python web service. It collects structured client responses across 10 sections, generates a branded PDF, and emails it automatically to the consultant via Resend — no SMTP configuration or credentials are shown to clients. Render watches the GitHub repo ([ericgitonga/career-transition-intake](#)) and redeploys automatically on every push to **main**.

After one-time setup, deploying a change means pushing to GitHub. That's it.

One-Time Setup

These steps are required once before the first deployment.

1. Create a Render account

Go to <https://render.com> and sign up — the free tier requires no credit card.

2. Connect your GitHub account

In the Render dashboard, click your avatar → **Account Settings** → **Git Provider** → **Connect GitHub**. Authorise Render to access the [ericgitonga/career-transition-intake](#) repo.

3. Create a new Web Service

- Click **New** → **Web Service**
- Select the **career-transition-intake** repository
- Render detects **render.yaml** automatically and fills in the settings
- Confirm: Runtime **Python**, Build Command **pip install -r requirements.txt**, Start Command **gunicorn app:app --bind 0.0.0.0:\$PORT**
- Instance type: **Free**
- Click **Create Web Service**

4. Sign up for Resend (email delivery)

Resend is a transactional email service that sends over HTTPS — it is never blocked by hosting providers the way SMTP is. The free tier allows 3,000 emails per month.

- Go to <https://resend.com> and sign up using the consultant's email address (e.g. [gitonga@gmail.com](#)) — this becomes the verified recipient address
- In the Resend dashboard, go to **API Keys** → **Create API Key**
- Give it a name (e.g. *career-transition-form*) and copy the key — it is shown only once

5. Add the Resend API key to Render

In the Render service dashboard, go to **Environment** and add one variable:

- **RESEND_API_KEY** — the API key copied from step 4

The app reads this from the environment automatically. Never put the key in the code or the repository.

Click **Save Changes** — Render triggers a redeploy to apply the variable.

How It Works

Client experience

Clients open the URL, complete the 10-section dark-themed accordion form, optionally upload documents (CV, LinkedIn export, job description, learning plan, and additional files), then click **Submit Onboarding Form**. The server generates a branded PDF, emails it to the consultant automatically, and triggers a download in the client's browser. No credentials, no email settings, and no configuration are shown to clients.

Email sender address

By default the form sends from **onboarding@resend.dev** (Resend's shared address). To send from a custom domain (e.g. *noreply@yourdomain.com*), verify the domain in the Resend dashboard and set a **FROM_EMAIL** environment variable in Render with the desired address.

Deploying Updates

Push any change to the main branch — Render picks it up and redeploys within ~2 minutes:

```
git push origin main
```

After Deployment

Your URL

Render assigns a permanent URL shown at the top of the service dashboard:

```
https://career-transition-intake.onrender.com
```

This URL does not change between deploys.

Free tier spin-down

On the free tier the service spins down after **15 minutes of inactivity**. The first request after a quiet period takes ~30 seconds to wake up. For a form shared on-demand this is acceptable — just warn clients that the first load may be briefly slow. To eliminate spin-down, upgrade to the **Starter** plan (\$7/month) or use a free uptime monitor such as UptimeRobot to ping the URL every 10 minutes.

Rotating the Resend API key

Go to the Resend dashboard, revoke the old key and create a new one. Then go to **Render** → **Environment**, update **RESEND_API_KEY**, and click **Save Changes**. Render redeploys automatically.